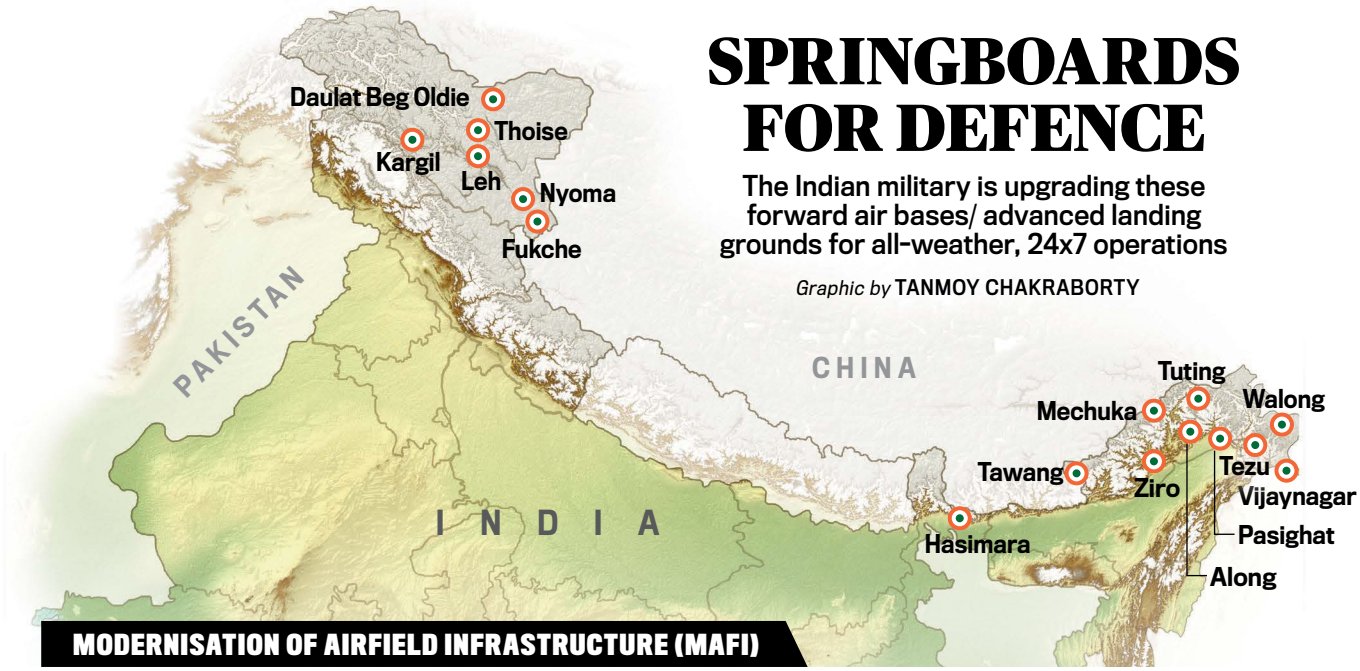
SPRINGBOARDS FOR DEFENCE

The Indian military is upgrading these forward air bases/ advanced landing grounds for all-weather, 24x7 operations

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY



MODERNISATION OF AIRFIELD INFRASTRUCTURE (MAFI)

Phase I (2011-2018) and Phase II (2020-): 30 IAF airfields

- Resurfacing, expansion, lighting of runways (CAT-II Airfield Lighting System) for night operations
- Installation of tactical air navigation system, system instrument landing system (CAT-II ILS), air-to-ground radio communication (RCAG) system
- These allow aircraft to operate 24x7 in all-weather, poor visibility conditions

stated that the second phase of airfield modernisation—part of a dual-phase project called Modernisation of Air Field Infrastructure (MAFI)—is underway. He said that a contract for the project, worth Rs 1,187 crore, was signed between the ministry of defence (MoD) and TATA Power SED in May 2020. Bhatt said the new features and systems to be installed will allow aircraft to take off and land in adverse weather conditions, as well as aid flights with night operations. Phase I of MAFI involved the upgrading of 30 IAF airfields and was signed on March 16, 2011, for Rs 1,215 crore. Phase II involves airfields of the IAF, the Indian Navy as well as the Indian Coast Guard. The new features and systems to be installed include CAT II Instrument Landing Systems (ILS) and CAT II Airfield Lighting Systems (AFLS). These systems will allow aircraft to take off and land in adverse weather through the day and night, thereby improving flight safety and frequency of operations.

STRONG CARRIERS

IAF's fleet of transport aircraft includes the Boeing C-17 Globemaster IIIs, the Ilyushin IL-76s, the Lockheed Martin C-130Js, the Antonov AN-32 / AN-32 RE, the Dornier 228 and the HS 748 Hawker Siddeley (Avro). There are also the Boeing CH-47 Chinook transport helicopters. The latest entrant is the Airbus C-295—which is equipped with the latest sensors and avionics. These, then, are the aircraft that will shoulder the task of transporting men and equipment swiftly at India's all-weather airfields during any contingency.

Inducted in the Indian military in 2011, the C-130J Super Hercules, the protagonist of the Kargil landing, has distinguished itself in several tough missions—it carried out a daring rescue of 121 Indians stranded in strife-hit Sudan in April 2023, landing at night on a small airstrip at Wadi Sayyidna without navigational aids or landing lights and, a few months later on November 15, landed at the rudimentary Dharasu airfield in Uttarakhand to deliver heavy equipment needed for the rescue mission at the collapsed Silkyara tunnel in Uttarkashi. Earlier, the C-130—equipped with an all-weather day-night capability with night vision



"THE IAF IS OPENING UP AREAS FOR QUICK INDUCTION OF TROOPS. THIS IS VITAL, GIVEN CHINA'S BELLIGERENCE IN LADAKH"

AIR VICE MARSHAL MANMOHAN BAHADUR (RETD)